
Squid Game Is Full of Deaths. But One Is Truly Devastating.

Published by

Nadira Goffe

Estimated reading time

8 min

Added on

2025-06-30

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2025/06/squid-game-season-3-netflix-players-hyun-ju-myung-gi-jun-hee-trans.html>

Squid Game Is Full of Deaths. But One Is Truly Devastating.

This article contains spoilers for Squid Game Season 3.

Squid Game, Netflix's bloody Korean series that became a global phenomenon when it first premiered in 2021, has never pulled its punches. The show—a gruesome and disturbing exploration of how capitalism undermines humanity and morality—found success using intense violence and clever storytelling, turning the concepts of childhood games into fatal events as part of a dystopian competition for survival and money. But *Squid Game*'s true strength lies in its ability to create unlikely heroes (and captivating villains) out of the most unassuming of characters, like [Ali in Season 1](#), [the nefarious Recruiter in Season 2](#), and, now, Hyun-ju, a transgender female character played by the actor Park Sung-hoon. Despite *Squid Game* centering around the resilient, yet somewhat idiotic, main character of Seong Gi-hun (Lee Jung-jae), it's Hyun-ju who has become the most captivating character in this final season, which premiered on Friday. Unfortunately, these unlikely *Squid Game* heroes and villains that define the show are tragic ones, and, as is typical for this series, Hyun-ju's story ends too soon, resulting in the most devastating death this season.

Cho Hyun-ju first arrives on *Squid Game* in Season 2—Seasons 2 and 3 tell one continuous story; you can think of them as two parts of the same season—as Player 120, a shy transgender woman who initially receives questionable looks from other players. But in the very first game of the deadly survival competition—the [infamous Red Light, Green Light game](#)—Hyun-ju proves herself to be of incredible character, risking her life to help Gi-hun carry an injured player over the line to safety. She does the same (though not necessarily by choice) when she agrees to team up with the anxiety-ridden Young-mi (Kim Si-eun) in the subsequent Six-Legged Pentathlon game. It's thanks to Hyun-ju's coaching and leadership that her team—which includes a group of misfits, many of whom go on to become Hyun-ju's trusted allies as the games continue—survive the Six-Legged Pentathlon.

We find out that Hyun-ju entered the life-or-death competition because her decision to transition got her fired from her job and ostracized by her friends and family. The lack of income and absence of a support system in the middle of her transition caused Hyun-ju to fall into debt, so she joined the games so she could pay off her debts and finish getting the surgeries needed to complete her transition. Hyun-ju quickly comes to represent a hero for the underdogs, someone who always stands up for and protects the weak. But she doesn't simply protect those players: She earnestly believes in their abilities to overcome challenges or bring something useful to the table. Hyun-ju doesn't see the world, or the games, in black-and-white terms of weakest links. Instead, because of her experiences, she believes in the value of life, perhaps more than any other player does.

Related From Slate



[Finally, *Squid Game* Focuses On Its Best Character in Season 2](#)

[Read More](#)

Kindness and compassion aside, the other part of Hyun-ju's appeal is her physical and intellectual dominance. Not only does she formulate and execute good game plans to survive the trials, but she also proves herself to be the player most adept at combat. When Gi-hun attempts to lead a revolt against the workers overseeing the games at the end of Season 2, Hyun-ju is the only woman who volunteers to join the fight. When the other rebels are shocked at her strong capabilities and battle and weapon knowledge, she reveals that before she transitioned, she was a highly trained and incredibly skilled sergeant in the ROK Special Forces. This, of course, takes the men who had judged or underestimated her by surprise. Even the fact that she had carried herself and her teammates to safety so far seemed to defy the prejudiced expectations of her fellow players.

Where Season 1 of *Squid Game* had a whole cast of equally interesting characters, making the show's stakes skyrocket as you realize they can't all survive, Seasons 2 and 3 have struggled to achieve that same level of depth among the mostly new slate of characters, whether because of lackluster acting or poor writing. There were some standouts: a mother-son duo, and Thanos, a struggling rapper with a drug addiction and an unfortunate brush with a failed cryptocurrency, played by [K-pop rapper T.O.P.](#) But none hold a candle to the emotional stakes that Hyun-ju embodies, easily making her [a fan-favorite character](#) in Season 2. Of course, Park Sung-hoon's phenomenal acting, approaching Hyun-ju with such depth and vulnerability, has much to do with this as well. Though this casting decision originally generated some controversy from viewers who were disappointed that Hwang Dong-hyuk, the show's creator, didn't cast a transgender woman for the role, Hwang addressed these complaints in an interview with [TV Guide](#), saying that "it was near impossible" to cast a trans actor, as he found that "there are close to no actors that are openly trans, let alone openly gay" in South Korea, given the marginalization that members of the LGBTQ+ community still face in the country.

But, as any *Squid Game* viewer knows, the good can't survive, because no one can (unless you're Gi-hun, the show's foolhardy main character). In Hyun-ju's case, she dies the way we would come to expect: while trying to save other people. Only two episodes into the final season, during a fatal game of Hide-and-Seek—in which the knife-armed seekers must murder at least one hider before the time is up, and hidere must avoid death by remaining hidden or by finding the exit door—Hyun-ju is randomly assigned a hider role. She vows to stick with the pregnant contestant Jun-hee (Jo Yu-ri) and Geum-ja (Kang Ae-shim), the mother of the mother-son duo—two vulnerable players who would otherwise be unlikely to survive the game. When Jun-hee fractures her ankle and then goes into labor while hiding, Hyun-ju stays on the lookout for seekers looking to murder them. She gets into a struggle with one, and their fight pushes them down the hallway into another room. After Hyun-ju manages to kill the man, she looks up and realizes she's inadvertently found the exit. Instead of stepping through the door and winning the game with her life intact, she selflessly runs back to the room to tell the ladies—where she gets stabbed in the back, ultimately dying.

Related From Slate



[Rebecca Onion](#)

[The Creator of Scream Has a New Netflix Hit. It's Salty, Soapy, and Fully Adult.](#)

[Read More](#)

There are layers to Hyun-ju's death. The man who killed her is Myung-gi (Im Si-wan), Jun-hee's former boyfriend and father to the newborn. He has spent the game murdering a number of hiders, after having switched positions with Jun-hee so that he could ostensibly protect her after doing his requisite murder. But instead, he has ruthlessly killed scores of people to grow the ultimate prize pot and increase his chances of surviving the competition, illustrating how power is a slippery slope and violence can be brutally indiscriminate. And, irony of all ironies, he kills the one person who has protected the mother of his child—and the main reason that his child was even able to make it into this world. Hyun-ju was his opposite, someone whose selflessness cost her her life in a world built for the hard-hearted to survive.

There's also the layer of what Hyun-ju's death represents because of her presence *in* the games. Hwang intended for the character to open viewers' eyes to the marginalization of LGBT characters, and Hyun-ju's presence in the story does just that. *Squid Game* was first known for highlighting how devastating it is that people without money are so desperate to survive that they feel the need to risk their lives for basic human rights or a higher standard of living, whether their misfortunes are a direct result of their actions or not. Hyun-ju's presence in the games showcases the grim reality of a trans person without the means to procure gender-affirming care, or even solidarity and understanding from the people in her life. Hyun-ju doesn't just battle for money in the arena—she also battles against discrimination every time she proves the judgmental men around her wrong, just as she battles for visibility and understanding when her allied players in the game validate her existence and her identity. Like everyone else, she's battling for her life—but then again, she was already doing that outside the games.

Get the best of culture

Get the best of movies, TV, books, music, and more.

Thanks for signing up! You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

You're already subscribed to the Culture newsletter. You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

We encountered an issue signing you up. Please try again, or [manage all your newsletter](#)

[subscriptions here](#) .

Please enable javascript to sign up for newsletters.

Email address:

Send me updates about Slate special offers.

By signing up, you agree to our [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms](#).

Sign Up

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.